

Yann Burden

AI and Technology Executive. Exited Founder.

+61 400 941 979 | yannburden@gmail.com | energyreturn.co/me | linkedin.com/in/yannburden

Working rights: Australia, UK, EU, Canada

Highlights

- Founded and scaled Billcap (multi-tenant SaaS for energy utilities) as CEO through to exit, building the data science and ML capability that powered the platform's core value proposition.
- Hired as CPTO at Pendula, led engineering, product and AI organisation through international expansion and acquisition by Smart Communications.
- Built and operated customer engagement platforms across 5 energy retailers and 250,000+ end users, each with distinct regulatory and operational requirements.
- Designed and shipped production ML systems across energy and customer engagement -- demand forecasting, behavioural segmentation, churn prediction, and conversational AI.
- Co-authored peer-reviewed research on energy demand elasticity and behavioural interventions with the University of Melbourne, grounded in large-scale field experiments.
- Venture Partner at Black Nova VC, coaching growth-stage portfolio founders on AI strategy, architecture decisions, and build discipline.

Focus

Energy and Utilities | Connected Platforms | AI and Data Science | Machine Learning | Customer Engagement | Scale-Up SaaS

Experience

Pendula | 2021 - 2025

Chief Product and Technology Officer

- Hired as CPTO. Led 25-person engineering, product and data team through to acquisition by Smart Communications.

- Designed and implemented the AI layer of Pendula's customer engagement platform: intent classification models for inbound message routing, next-best-action recommendation engines for outbound orchestration, and sentiment analysis pipelines processing millions of customer interactions.
- Built and deployed conversational AI agents using LLMs for enterprise customer communication -- prompt engineering, retrieval-augmented generation, evaluation frameworks, and production monitoring.
- Architected the data pipeline infrastructure underpinning AI features: event streaming, feature stores, and model serving on cloud infrastructure (AWS).
- Unlocked additional \$5M ARR by leading enterprise product focus, with AI-driven personalisation as the key differentiator.
- Set up London offices as part of international growth strategy post Series A, signed first UK deal.

DC Power Co | 2018 - 2021

Chief Customer and Technology Officer

- Founding executive team of Australia's first crowd-funded renewable energy retailer. Acquired by Ion Group.
- Developed in-house customer engagement product reducing churn by over 25%, using predictive churn models built on usage patterns, billing data, and behavioural signals.
- Delivered strategic NPS of +51 in first year of operation.
- Set up digital sales channel delivering market-leading conversion rates for battery storage.

Billcap | 2011 - 2018

CEO and Co-founder

- Co-founded and led company delivering customer engagement SaaS platform to energy retailers and distributors. Sold to Tally Group for 8x investor return.
- Hands-on technical contributor: prototyped ML models for outlier detection, consumption prediction, and household segmentation in R, working directly with smart meter interval data across 250,000+ users.
- Established pioneering research partnership with the University of Melbourne for behavioural science field experiments in energy consumption and demand response.
- Developed the data ingestion and processing pipelines for high-volume smart meter data (30-minute interval reads), handling data quality, imputation, and regulatory reporting requirements.
- Grew client base to 5 energy companies across retail and distribution, each with distinct metering infrastructure, tariff structures, and regulatory contexts.

Earlier Experience

- **Energy Return** | 2009 - 2011 | Founder and MD. Energy efficiency consulting for local government.
 - **Cool Nrg** | 2007 - 2009 | General Manager (France). Nation-wide residential energy efficiency and carbon abatement for energy retailers.
 - **Accenture (UK)** | 2005 - 2007 | Technology Strategy Manager. CIO advisory, IT organisation design, telco strategy.
 - **Unilog (France)** | 2004 | Technology Strategy. Energy retail focus.
 - **PwC Consulting** | 1999 - 2002 | SAP Consultant.
-

Advisory and Boards

Black Nova Venture Capital -- Venture Partner, AI Advisory (2025 -)

University of Melbourne -- Honorary Industry Fellow, School of Computing and Information Systems (2015 - 2024)

Bendigo Bank Community Bank -- Non-Executive Director (2010 - 2017)

Education

University of Melbourne -- Bachelor of Science (Information Systems), 1998

Selected Publications and Research

Billcap's smart meter data underpinned a multi-year research programme with the University of Melbourne.

- "Power from the People" (La Nauze, 2019) -- *Journal of Political Economy* (top-5). Acknowledges "Yann Burden and Billcap for access to proprietary data."
- "Tell Me Something I Don't Already Know" (Byrne, La Nauze, Martin, 2018) -- *Review of Economics and Statistics* (top-5)